

Your Guide to Healthy Living

Tips to Help You Get and Stay Healthy



Memorial Sloan Kettering
Cancer Center

What will you find inside this guide?

The information in this guide can help you stay healthy. You'll find pages about common health problems like high blood pressure, cholesterol, and diabetes. You'll also learn about eating better, getting more exercise, and keeping your body strong.

You can feel better, take care of your health, or learn about ways to prevent illness. Inside this guide, you'll find simple steps you can use every day. Small changes can make a big difference. Are you ready to start living a healthier life?

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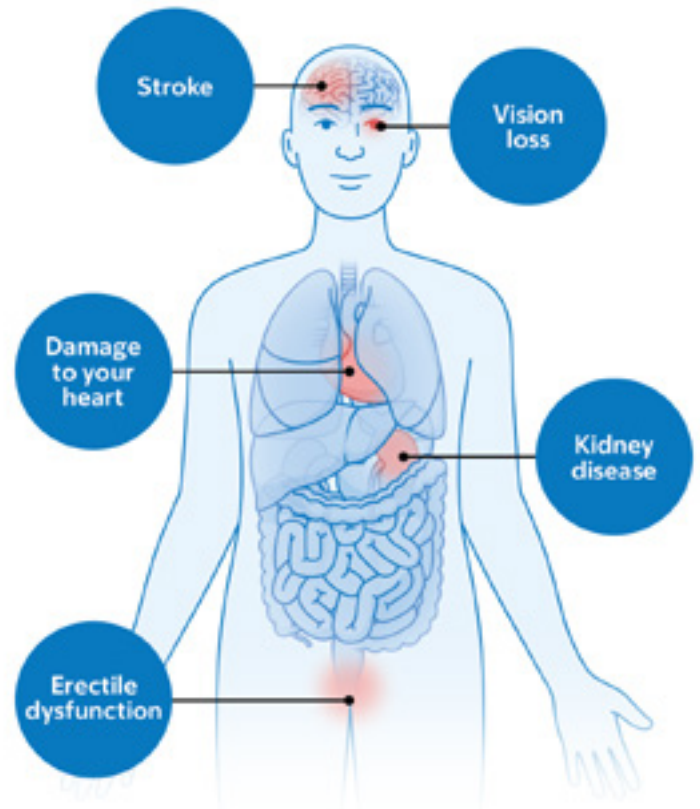
What is High Blood Pressure (Hypertension)?

Blood pressure is the pressure that your blood puts on the walls of your arteries. An artery is a blood vessel (tube) that carries blood from your heart to the rest of your body.

High blood pressure is also called hypertension. It's when the force of your blood pressing against your artery walls is too high. High blood pressure usually has no symptoms. You may not know you have it until your blood pressure is checked.

Most people don't know they have high blood pressure. This is why it is often called the “silent killer.”

High blood pressure can cause problems, such as:



Talk with your healthcare provider

Sometimes making healthy choices is not enough to keep blood pressure under control.

Talk with your healthcare provider about getting checked and whether medicines are right for you.

Understanding the Numbers

Blood pressure is measured and written as one number over another.

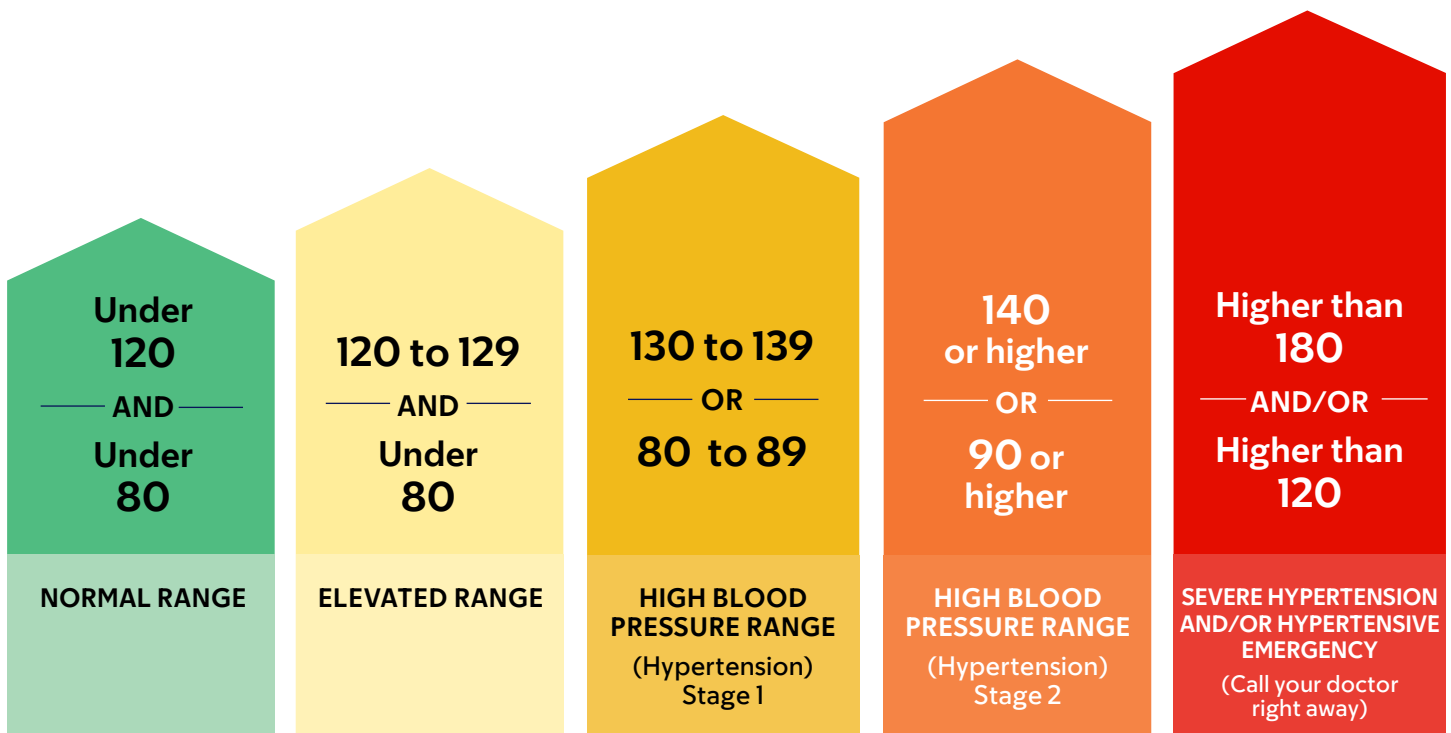
118
— mm Hg
77

The **top number** is your **systolic** which measures how much pressure your blood puts on your artery walls when your heart beats.

The **bottom number** is your **diastolic blood pressure**. It measures how much pressure your blood is putting on your artery walls when your heart rests between beats.

One or both of these numbers can be too high. If these numbers are too high, you may have hypertension. The chart below shows the ranges for healthy and unhealthy blood pressure levels.

Your Guide to the 5 Types of Blood Pressure Ranges



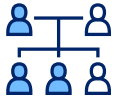
Recommendations by the American Heart Association

Call 911 right away if you have any of these symptoms: chest pain, shortness of breath, back pain, numbness, changes to your vision, or having trouble speaking. These may be signs of a hypertensive emergency or other emergency.

Your Risk For High Blood Pressure

A risk factor is anything that can raise your chances of getting a disease. Knowing your risk factors can help you talk with your care team. They can recommend things you can do to lower your risk.

There are some risk factors for high blood pressure that are out of your control, such as:



Your family history. Your family are people who you are related to by blood.



Your race and ethnicity. For example, in the United States high blood pressure affects the Black community at a higher rate than any other race.



Your age

However, there are healthy habits that can lower your risk of having high blood pressure. The good news is these habits can help even if you have other risk factors.

Things you can do to lower your risk of high blood pressure include:



Eat more fruits, vegetables, beans, and legumes.



Do not smoke cigarettes, use tobacco, or vape (electronic-cigarettes).

Exercise as often as you can.



Do not drink alcohol regularly.



Maintain a healthy weight for your body.



Limit foods high in sodium (salt). For example, a lot of processed foods contain extra sodium your body does not need.

Talk to your doctor about ways to control your blood pressure and maintain a healthy lifestyle.

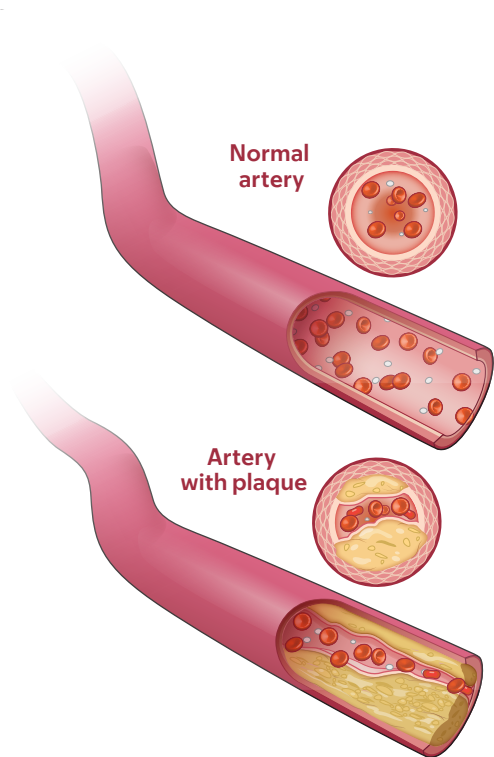


What is Cholesterol?

Cholesterol is a waxy, fat like substance in your blood. Everyone has cholesterol. Your liver makes all the cholesterol you need. The rest of the cholesterol in your body generally comes from food that are from animals such as meat, eggs, cheese, and milk.

What are Triglycerides?

Triglycerides (try-gliss-ERR-ride-z) are a type of fat. They are the most common type of fat in your body. When you eat, your body changes the calories it does not need into triglycerides.



What happens when your cholesterol or triglycerides are too high?

When you have high cholesterol, or high triglycerides, in your blood it can cause plaque (pla-ACK). Plaque is a sticky substance that can grow on the walls of an artery. An artery is a thin, tube-like structure that carries blood towards and away from your heart. This can limit (lower) blood flow to your heart and other areas of the body. Having plaque in your arteries can lead to cardiovascular disease (CVD).

Here are some foods you should limit:

- Whole milk dairy products, such as cheese.
- Fatty and processed meats, such as bacon, sausage, and hot dogs.
- Solid fats, such as butter, shortening or lard.
- Fried or “fast” foods.
- “White” carbs, such as white bread, white rice, muffins.
- Candy, sweets, and desserts.



Get a Cholesterol Test

You need a blood test to know your cholesterol levels. This test may be called a cholesterol test, a lipid panel, or a lipid profile. Follow your healthcare provider’s instructions carefully so that you get the correct test results.

Your cholesterol test will measure 4 types of lipids (fats) in your blood:

- **Low Density Lipoproteins (LDL)** is “bad” cholesterol. LDL can buildup and clog your arteries (blood vessels).
- **High Density Lipoproteins (HDL)** is “good” cholesterol. HDL takes the bad cholesterol away from your arteries.
- **Triglycerides.**
 - **Total cholesterol.**

	Total	LDL	HDL	Triglycerides
Ideal	Less than 200	Less than 100	More than 60	Less than 150
Borderline	200 to 239	130 to 159	Female: 40 to 59 Male: 50 to 59	150 to 199
Too high	More than 240	High: 160 to 189 Very high: more than 190	Female: less than 40 Male: less than 50	High: 200 to 499 Very high: more than 500

Figure 1: A table of cholesterol levels for people who do not have risk factors for CVD.

Here are some foods you should eat to help keep your cholesterol at a healthy level:



- Colorful fruits and vegetables
- Whole grain bread and pasta
- Brown rice
- Low-fat or non-fat dairy
- Chicken
- Fish
- Nuts and seeds
- Beans and legumes
- Plant-seed oils like avocado, olive oil, or sunflower seed oil

What is Type 2 Diabetes?

Type 2 diabetes is a disease in which your blood glucose (sugar) levels are too high.

Your body makes a hormone called insulin. It helps move glucose (sugar) out of your blood and into your cells. The glucose gives your cells energy.

When you have type 2 diabetes, your body does not make enough insulin or use it the way it should. This causes the glucose to stay in your blood. That can lead to serious health problems, such as heart disease and stroke.

Type 2 diabetes can happen when we don't eat healthy foods, exercise enough, or are overweight. If you have or are at risk for Type 2 diabetes, making small, healthy changes can make a difference.

Type 2 diabetes is the most common type of diabetes, so it's important to know if you're at risk.

Signs of type 2 diabetes

Signs of type 2 diabetes often develop slowly, so you may not notice them.

Some people don't have any signs at all. Some signs of diabetes include:



Being very thirsty or hungry.



Having cuts or bruises that are slow to heal.



Feeling more tired than usual.



Having blurry vision.



Urinating (peeing) more than usual.



Feeling numb or tingling in your hands or feet.



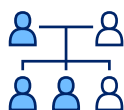
Losing weight without trying.

Risk factors for type 2 diabetes

There are some risk factors for type 2 diabetes that are out of your control, such as:



Your age



Your family history.

Your family are people who you are related to by blood.



Your race and ethnicity.

There are risk factors that you may be able to control, including:



Being overweight.



Not exercising.



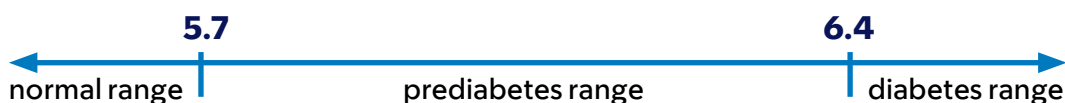
Eating a lot of foods high in sugar and carbohydrates.

What is prediabetes?

Prediabetes means your blood sugar is higher than normal. It's not high enough to be diabetes. Many people have prediabetes before they are diagnosed with type 2 diabetes. Prediabetes is your body's warning to be careful. You might not feel sick, but acting now can stop prediabetes from turning into diabetes.

Hemoglobin A1c is a blood test used to check your blood sugar. It shows your average blood sugar over the past 3 months.

- 5.6 and lower is normal
- 5.7 to 6.4 means you may have prediabetes.
- 6.5 and higher means you may have type 2 diabetes.



You can lower your hemoglobin A1c by making healthy food and drink choices. Exercise can lower your blood sugar too.

Here are foods and drinks you can enjoy to help lower your blood sugar:

- Colorful vegetables
- Legumes, lentils, and beans
- Whole grains
- Tap and sparkling water
- Drinks with no or low sugar



Here are foods and drinks you should limit to keep your blood sugar at a normal level:

- Soda
- Energy drinks
- Juice
- Fast food
- Desserts and candy
- Wine, beer, hard seltzers, and mixed drinks



What is Cardiovascular Disease (CVD)?

Cardiovascular disease, also known as CVD, means the heart and blood vessels are not working the way they should.

When your heart beats, it pumps blood through your blood vessels to all parts of your body. Your blood carries oxygen and nutrients. If there is a problem with your heart or blood vessels, it means your body is not getting what it needs.



There are many types of CVD. Some you may know about, including:

- Heart attack
- Ischemic (is-KEE-mick) stroke
- Heart failure
- Hemorrhagic (hem-or-AJ-ICK) stroke

Risk factors for CVD

A risk factor is anything that can increase your chances of a health problem.

There are some risk factors for CVD that are out of your control, such as:



Your age. As you get older, your risk for developing CVD goes up.



Your family history. If a person related to you by blood had CVD, you are more likely to have it too.

There are risk factors that you can control, including:



Being overweight.



High cholesterol.



If you smoke cigarettes, cigars, or vape (electronic cigarettes).



High blood pressure.



What you eat.



Type 2 diabetes.

What you can do to lower your risk of CVD



Eat more fruits, vegetables, beans, and legumes.



Get help to quit smoking cigarettes, using tobacco, or cigars.

Exercise as often as you can.



Maintain a healthy weight for your body.



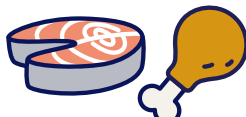
Balance your meals by eating more lean proteins, leafy green vegetables (collards, kale, spinach), and whole grains.

How to Measure Healthy Portion Sizes

A portion size is the amount of food you put on your plate. Your portion is how much of the food on your plate you choose to eat. Paying attention to your food portions can help lower the chances of overeating. This can help you manage your weight.

Knowing what a healthy portion size looks like can be hard. There are different portion sizes for each food group you want to add to your plate.

Your hand is a great tool to help you measure and see healthy portion sizes. Use the guide below to help you see how much of each food type you should be eating in 1 portion.

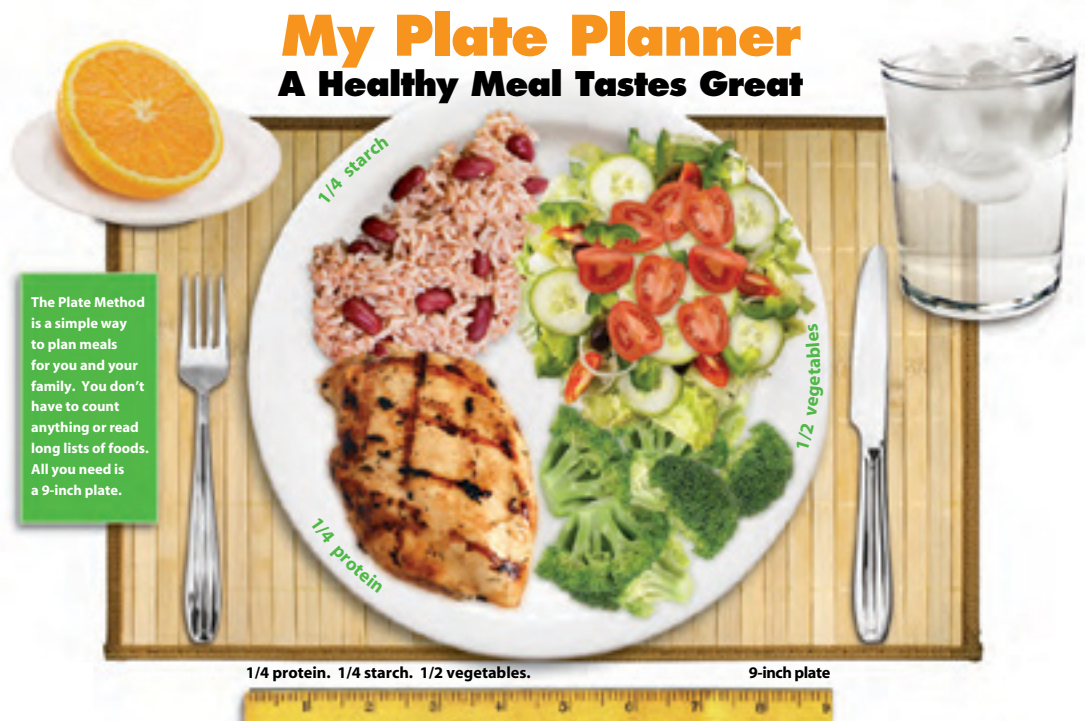
Hand Measurement	Equals to	Food types
Fingertip 	1 teaspoon 	Cooking oils, sugar, butter 
Thumb 	1 tablespoon 	Nut butter, hard cheese 
Cupped hand 	1 ounce 	Nuts 
Palm 	1/4 cup 	Meat, fish, poultry 
1 fist 	1 cup 	Rice, pasta, beans, lentils, legumes, white potatoes 
2 fists 	2 cups 	Vegetables, fruits 

Memorial Sloan Kettering Cancer Center's (MSK) registered dietitians have menu ideas and recipes for you.

Point the camera of your smart phone or tablet and scan the QR code. Then tap the link to open the website.



Easy Ways to... Build a Healthy Meal



Fill half of your plate with **fruits and vegetables**. Choose colorful foods to brighten your meal.

Add **lean protein**. Choose proteins like beans, nuts, tofu, fish, and lean or low-fat meat and poultry.

Make at least half of your grains **whole grains**. Look for the words "100% whole grain" or "100% whole wheat" on the Nutrition Facts label.

Add a **healthy beverage**. Drink water or plain fat-free or low-fat milk.

This material was funded by United States Department of Agriculture's (USDA) Supplemental Assistance Program (SNAP). SNAP, formerly known as the Food Stamp Program (FSP) in New York, provides nutrition assistance to people with low incomes. It can help you buy nutritious foods for a better diet. To find out more, contact 800-342-3009 or go to myBenefits.ny.gov. USDA is an equal opportunity provider and employer. In accordance with Federal law and USDA policy, this institution is prohibited from discriminating on the basis of race, color, national origin, sex, age, religion, political beliefs or disability. To file a complaint of discrimination, write USDA, Director of Civil Rights, Room 326-W, Whitten Building, 1400 Independence Avenue, SW, Washington, D.C. 20250 or call 202-720-5964 (voice and TDD).



Just Say Yes to Fruits and Vegetables

Easy Ways to... Use the Nutrition Facts Label

1. Start with serving size.

Check the number of servings per container and the size of each serving. The Nutrition Facts are based on one serving.

2. Aim to meet your daily calorie goal.

3. Limit:

- Saturated fat
- Trans fat
- Cholesterol
- Sodium
- Added sugars

4. Eat enough:

- Fiber
- Vitamin D
- Calcium
- Iron
- Potassium

5. Pay attention to the % (Percent) Daily Value (DV):

- 5 percent or less is **LOW**
- 20 percent or more is **HIGH**

Nutrition Facts

8 servings per container

Serving size 2/3 cup (55g)

Amount Per Serving

Calories 230

	% Daily Value*
Total Fat 8g	10%
Saturated Fat 1g	5%
Trans Fat 0g	
Cholesterol 0mg	0%
Sodium 160mg	7%
Total Carbohydrate 37g	13%
Dietary Fiber 4g	14%
Total Sugars 12g	
Includes 10g Added Sugars	20%
Protein 3g	6%
Vitamin D 2mcg	10%
Calcium 260mg	20%
Iron 8mg	45%
Potassium 235mg	6%

*The % Daily Value (DV) tells you how much a nutrient in a serving of food contributes to a daily diet. 2,000 calories a day is used for general nutrition advice.

This material was funded by the United States Department of Agriculture (USDA) Supplemental Assistance Program (SNAP).

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Just Say Yes to Fruits and Vegetables

Easy Ways to... Add More Fruits and Vegetables to Your Meals

Brighten up your plate with colorful fruits and vegetables at every meal.

Breakfast



Mix fruit with yogurt, oatmeal or whole grain cereal.



Include vegetables in an omelet or egg sandwich.



Make a smoothie with leafy greens and frozen fruit.

Lunch and Dinner



Add vegetables to soups, stews or casseroles.



Mix vegetables with pasta, rice or couscous



Top tacos, pizzas and pita bread with vegetables.

Snacks



Enjoy fruit with peanut butter.



Add vegetables to half of a sandwich.



Serve fresh vegetables with a bean dip.

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Just Say Yes to Fruits and Vegetables

Easy Ways to... Eat Enough Fiber

Fiber may lower your risk of heart disease. Most adults need **25 grams** of fiber each day. Look how easy it is!

Instead of...

Eat...



Half a bagel =
1 gram of fiber



$\frac{1}{2}$ cup oatmeal =
4 grams of fiber



A glass of juice =
1 gram of fiber



One medium orange =
3 grams of fiber



A handful of chips =
1 gram of fiber



A handful of nuts =
4 grams of fiber



A cup of white rice =
0.5 gram of fiber



$\frac{1}{2}$ cup of brown rice
and $\frac{1}{4}$ cup of beans =
6 grams of fiber



A pudding cup =
0.5 gram of fiber



1 cup blueberries =
3 grams of fiber

Total Fiber: 4 grams

Total Fiber: 25 grams!

Tips for Eating More Fiber:

- Eat whole fruits and vegetables instead of juices, which have little to no fiber.
- Fruit and vegetable skins contain a lot of fiber. Wash and eat the peel.
- Check the Nutrition Facts label and choose foods with at least 10 percent Daily Value for fiber.
- Read the ingredients list and choose foods with whole grains listed first.



Easy Ways to... Eat a Variety of Proteins

Eat a variety of proteins as part of a healthy diet. Eat plant proteins more often.

Beans and Lentils	Nuts and Seeds	Lean Animal Proteins
 Make a three bean salad.	 Spread nut butter on apple or banana slices.	 Choose fish twice a week.
 Add beans to sautéed greens and eat with brown rice.	 Add nuts to vegetables and salads.	 Eat lean meat and poultry in the right portions – about the size of your palm.
 Make a bean dip to enjoy with vegetables.	 Snack on a handful of unsalted nuts or seeds.	 Bring a hard boiled egg with you for an easy snack.

Every Sip Adds Up

Sugary drinks are linked to cavities, weight gain, type 2 diabetes and heart disease.

20-ounce soda



About **16** teaspoons of sugar



240 calories

It would take 4,500 steps
to burn off this drink.*

20-ounce sports drink



About **9** teaspoons of sugar



140 calories

It would take 2,500 steps
to burn off this drink.*

16-ounce energy drink



About **14** teaspoons of sugar

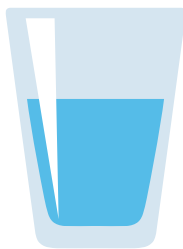


220 calories

It would take 4,000 steps
to burn off this drink.*

*Numbers may vary based on weight, height and the amount of energy expended.

Choose New York City tap water!



- ✓ **0** teaspoons of sugar
- ✓ **0** calories
- ✓ **Healthy**
- ✓ **Clean**
- ✓ **Free**
- ✓ **Refreshing**

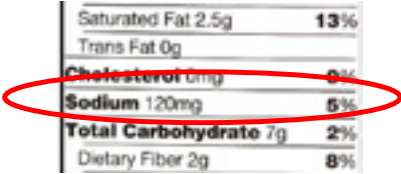


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Just Say Yes to Fruits and Vegetables

Easy Ways to... Cut the Salt

At the Store	At Home
- Choose foods with less than 5 percent Daily Value of sodium (salt) per serving.  - Buy whole foods as often as possible. - Fill your cart with fruits and vegetables. - If buying packaged foods, choose those labeled: ✓ "Low-sodium" ✓ "Sodium free" ✓ "No salt added" - Instead of processed or cured meats, choose: ✓ Lean cuts of meat and poultry ✓ Fish ✓ Beans and legumes - Instead of quick-cooking rice mixes and noodles, choose: ✓ Brown rice ✓ Whole wheat noodles and pasta ✓ Whole cornmeal - Instead of salty snack foods, choose: ✓ Fresh vegetables with a bean dip ✓ Whole grain crackers ✓ Plain, lightly salted popcorn	- Make homemade soups and broths. - Rinse canned beans and vegetables with water to reduce the amount of sodium.  - Create salt-free spice blends using your favorite spices. - Add vinegar, lemon or orange zest and/or juice to foods.  - Flavor foods with fresh and dried herbs, spices and low sodium soy sauce. - Avoid adding salt to the water when cooking beans, rice, pasta and vegetables.  - Slowly cut back on the amount of salt you add to food, until you are using little to no salt.

Design Your Fitness Program

Finding time to exercise can be a challenge. Try following these tips to help you start:



Check in with a healthcare provider.

Talk with a healthcare provider when you are ready to start a fitness program. Your care team can also give you advice on what exercises you should try.



Go at your own pace.

It's okay to start slowly if you are new to exercise. You can gradually increase your activity as you feel more confident.



Plan how much time you need.

Most adults need at least **150 minutes** of exercise each week. That is **30 minutes, 5 days a week.**



Build activity into your daily routine.

- Get off the subway or bus 1 to 2 stops before your stop. Walk the rest of the way there.
- If you are a driver, park your car and walk up and down the block for 10 minutes.
- Walk with a friend on your lunch break.
- Walk your child to school.
- If you can, ride a bike to do errands or to work.



Do activities you enjoy.

When fitness feels fun, you will look forward to doing it. Try adding variety to your fitness plan by doing different activities. Here are some types of exercises you can try:

Low (gentle) impact:

- Yoga
- Tai chi
- Casual (slow) walking
- Pilates
- Swimming

Moderate impact:

- Brisk (quick) walking
- Barre
- Bodyweight strength training
- Beginner aerobics
- Rowing

Vigorous (intense) impact:

- Running
- Weight training
- High impact aerobics
- Basketball
- Soccer
- Martial arts
- Indoor cycling

Disease Prevention and Health Screenings

Memorial Sloan Kettering Cancer Center (MSK) experts agree making changes to improve your health can lower your risk of cancer. This is also called preventative or preventive care.

There are things you can start to do to improve your health and prevent health problems, including:



Get your flu shot every year.



Maintain a healthy weight for your body.



Get vaccinated for Human Papilloma Virus (HPV). HPV is the most common sexually transmitted infection (STI). It can cause 8 different types of cancer.



Exercise for at least 30 minutes 5 times a week.



Do not smoke cigarettes, cigars, use tobacco, or use electronic cigarettes (vape).



Eat a healthy diet.



Do not drink alcohol or cut down.



Talk with a healthcare provider about getting checked for high blood pressure, high cholesterol and type 2 diabetes.



Wear sunscreen.



See your dentist for routine cleanings. They can check for signs of mouth and throat cancer.



Meet with a MSK Health Navigator for help improving your health.



Call 646-599-6707 on your phone or on WhatsApp.

Cancer Prevention and Screening: Know When To Start

Early cancer screening can save your life.

MSK experts have guidelines for people with an average risk of disease. You may be at higher risk depending on your family history and other factors. Your healthcare team can talk with you about your risk factors and any screening tests you need.

Cancer screening is checking for cancer when you don’t have symptoms. Screenings can help find cancer early, when it’s easier to treat. Cancer screening can help save your life.

There are things you can do to help prevent cancer or catch it early, including:

- 

Get a breast exam. Mammograms, ultrasounds, and breast MRI are all types of screening tests.
- 

Check your skin for new or changing moles (spots).
- 

Get a pap test to find any abnormal (not normal) cells in your cervix. This may be a sign of cervical cancer.
- 

If you smoke, or have smoked, ask your healthcare provider if you are eligible for lung cancer screening.
- 

Get a colonoscopy (koh-low-NAAS-KOH-pee) or stool (poop) based test to look for signs of colon cancer and polyps.
- 

Ask your healthcare provider about a prostate-specific antigen (PSA) blood test to screen for prostate cancer.

Here are MSK’s cancer screening guidelines:

CANCER	SCREENING TEST	AGES
Colorectal	Colonoscopy every 10 years	45 and older
Cervical	Pap test every 3 years You may also need an HPV test every 5 years	21 to 65
Breast	Breast exam every year by your doctor Mammogram every year	25 and older 40 and older
Prostate	First (baseline) PSA test Repeat PSA test as recommended	45 and older 50 to 70
Lung	Low-dose CT scan every year if you are eligible.*	50 to 80

*Your care team will ask about your smoking history to see if you qualify for lung screening. You may be eligible if you have smoked an average of 1 pack a day for at least 20 years. Or, you smoked a similar amount, such as 2 packs a day for 10 years.

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Learn more about MSK

Point your camera from your smart device at the QR code and tap the link.



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